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Haan, Annet den

2025, Article / Letter to editor (Journal of the History of Ideas, 86, 2, (2025), pp. 325-337)

Doi link to publisher: <https://doi.org/10.1353/jhi.2025.a959037>

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Download date: 2026-05-10

Note:

To cite this publication please use the final published version (if applicable).

Patristic Translations and the Patronage of Pope Nicholas V (r. 1447–55)

Annet den Haan

INTRODUCTION

This paper discusses the translations of Greek patristic texts that were made for Pope Nicholas V (r. 1447–55), in the context of that pope's translation patronage. Nicholas sponsored many Greek-Latin translations in the middle of the fifteenth century.¹ Among these were six translations of Greek Christian authors: John Chrysostom, Eusebius of Caesarea, Cyril of Alexandria, Gregory of Nazianzus, and Basil the Great.² Patristic studies, and specifically new translations of patristic texts, had become popular with humanists in Florence in the first half of the fifteenth century. The Church Fathers appealed to Italian humanists because of their proximity to both classical antiquity and the pristine Christian church. One factor that stimulated the humanists' new interest in patristic texts was the Council of Ferrara-Florence (1438–39), where a reconciliation between the Greek and Latin churches was attempted.³ Nicholas V became pope shortly after this

¹ On Nicholas, see, e.g., Massimo Miglio, "Niccolò V," *Enciclopedia dei papi* (Rome: Istituto dell'Enciclopedia Italiana, 2000); Aldo Landi, "Il pontificato di Niccolò V tra medioevo e prima metà moderna," *Archivio Storico Italiano* 158, no. 3 (2000): 553–61.

² Although these authors are not universally regarded as Church Fathers in today's literature, I treat them here as one category, because that is how they were seen at the time.

³ Charles L. Stinger, *Humanism and the Church Fathers: Ambrogio Traversari (1386–1439) and the Italian Renaissance* (Albany: State University of New York Press, 1977);

council, and during his pontificate, Constantinople was captured by the Ottoman Turks. His translation patronage arose from his wish to establish Rome as the cultural capital of the Christian world and to preserve the literary heritage of the dwindling Byzantine empire. These circumstances raise the question of whether patristic translations held a special place within his translation program.

Although Nicholas's translation patronage has been frequently discussed, the six patristic translations that were dedicated to him have not been studied specifically.⁴ Here I will consider their status within Nicholas's translation program by examining his involvement in the translation process, as well as the dissemination of these translations.

NICHOLAS'S COLLECTIONS AND LITERARY PATRONAGE

Before becoming pope, Tommaso Parentucelli, as he was then called, moved in humanist circles in Florence. In the 1440s, he authored a library canon—a list of books that every library ought to have—for Cosimo de' Medici.⁵ Tommaso's list, comprising ninety-eight authors, focuses mostly on Latin books, including Greek books in Latin translation. While classical Greek authors are hardly represented, the list includes many Greek patristic au-

Charles L. Stinger, "Italian Renaissance Learning and the Church Fathers," in *The Reception of the Church Fathers in the West: From the Carolingians to the Maurists*, ed. Irena Backus (Leiden: Brill, 1996), 2:473–511; Judith Herrin and Stuart McManus, "Renaissance Encounters: Byzantium Meets the West at the Council of Ferrara-Florence 1438–39," in *Renaissance Encounters: Greek East and Latin West*, ed. Marina S. Brownlee and Dimitri H. Gondicas (Leiden: Brill, 2013), 35–56.

⁴ For Nicholas's translation patronage, see Domenico Giorgi, *Vita Nicolai Quinti* (Rome: ex typographia Palearinorum, 1742), 175–97; Georg Voigt, *Die Wiederbelebung des klassischen Alterthums oder das erste Jahrhundert des Humanismus* (Berlin: Georg Reimer, 1859), 348–65; Ludwig von Pastor, *The History of the Popes from the Close of the Middle Ages*, trans. F. Antrobus (London: Kegan Paul, Trench, Trübner & Co., 1891), 2:193–214. For Nicholas and the Church Fathers, see Concetta Bianca, "Il pontificato di Niccolò V e i padri della chiesa," in *Umanesimo e padri della chiesa: Manoscritti e incunabuli di testi patristici da Francesco Petrarca al primo cinquecento*, ed. Sebastiano Gentile (Firenze: Rose, 1997), 85–92 and Massimo Miglio, "Niccolò V: Umanista di Cristo," in *Umanesimo e padri della chiesa*, 77–83, esp. 77. Stinger gives an overview of the patristic translations dedicated to Nicholas: Stinger, "Italian Renaissance Learning," 491–501.

⁵ Maria Grazia Blasio, Cinzia Lelj, and Giuseppina Roselli, "Un contributo alla lettura del canone bibliografico di Tommaso Parentucelli," in *Le chiavi della memoria: Miscellanea in occasione del I centenario della Scuola vaticana di paleografia, diplomatica e archivistica* (Vatican City: Scuola vaticana di paleografia, diplomatica e archivistica, 1984), 125–65.

thors whose works had already been translated into Latin in the Middle Ages, such as Dionysius the Areopagite, Origen, Eusebius, Gregory of Nazianzus, Basil, Athanasius, Chrysostom, and Didymus of Alexandria. In several places, Tommaso recommended including “any work available in Latin” by a certain author, which suggests that he would have welcomed more Latin translations.⁶ That he was interested in such translations is also apparent in other sources. Cardinal Bessarion (1403–72), who would later become a key figure in the humanist translation movement, made a translation of Basil’s *De nativitate Domini* for him.⁷ Tommaso was also closely involved with the patristic renditions of Ambrogio Traversari (1386–1439), and specifically with Traversari’s work on Dionysius the Areopagite.⁸

When Nicholas became pope, he embarked on an ambitious program of literary patronage. He laid the foundation for the Vatican library, investing in both the Greek and the Latin collections.⁹ He gathered manuscripts of Greek and Latin classics, and he also sponsored new Latin translations from the Greek. The Florentine biographer Vespasiano da Bisticci (1421–98), himself a prominent bookseller, wrote about Nicholas’s activities.¹⁰ He described how Nicholas gathered learned men at his court, provided an income for them, and gave them additional rewards when they brought him a finished translation, “so that they did all the more willingly what they had to do.”¹¹ These rewards were indeed handsome: Vespasiano mentioned that Nicholas gave Guarino Veronese five hundred florins for his translation of

⁶ For example, about Chrysostom he writes: “Homelie ipsius plures, que iamdudum traducte sunt, et quicquid ipsius latine habetur.” Blasio, Lelj, and Roselli, “Un contributo,” 134.

⁷ The letter of dedication is edited in Ludwig Mohler, *Kardinal Bessarion als Theologe, Humanist, und Staatsmann: Funde und Forschungen* (Aalen: Scientia Verlag, 1967; reprint of Paderborn, 1942), 3:452–53 (text no. 16). According to Mohler (p. 452), the work must have been written between 1441 and 1446.

⁸ On this translation, see Stinger, *Humanism and the Church Fathers*, 158–61.

⁹ On Nicholas’s Greek library, see Robert Devreesse, *Le fonds grec de la Bibliothèque vaticane des origines à Paul V* (Vatican City: Biblioteca Apostolica Vaticana, 1965). Also, with a critical discussion of Devreesse’s identifications, Antonio Manfredi, “Noti preliminari sulla sezione greca nella Vaticana di Niccolò V,” in *Niccolò V nel sesto centenario della nascita: Atti del convegno internazionale di studi* (Sarzana, 8–10 Ottobre 1998), ed. Franco Bonatti and Antonio Manfredi (Vatican City: Biblioteca Apostolica Vaticana, 2000), 57–70. For the Latin collection, see Antonio Manfredi, *I codici latini di Niccolò V: Edizione degli inventari e identificazione dei manoscritti* (Vatican City: Biblioteca Apostolica Vaticana, 1994). For Nicholas’s library project in general, see Antonio Manfredi, “The Vatican Library of Pope Nicholas V: The Project of a Universal Library in the Age of Humanism,” *Library History* 14, no. 2 (1998): 103–10.

¹⁰ Vespasiano’s biography of Nicholas is edited in Vespasiano da Bisticci, *Le vite*, ed. Aulo Greco (Florence: Istituto Palazzo Strozzi, 1970–1976), 1:35–82.

¹¹ “[...] aciochè facessino più volentieri quello avevano a fare.” Da Bisticci, *Le vite*, 1:63.

each of the three parts of Strabo's *De situ orbis*, and that he rewarded Niccolò Perotti with five hundred ducats for his translation of Polybius.¹²

Vespasiano also commented on the vision behind Nicholas's literary patronage: "It was the design of Pope Nicholas to found a library at S. Peter's for the general use of the Roman court, and this would have been a wonderful work could he have accomplished it; but, forestalled by death, he left it unfinished. For the elucidation of the Holy Scriptures he caused quantities of books to be translated: likewise many pagan writings and certain works of grammar necessary for the study of Latin."¹³ Vespasiano's comment suggests that Nicholas was particularly interested in translations that bore relevance to the Bible, as opposed to works from pagan antiquity; and if that was the case, one would expect to find many patristic texts among the "quantities of books" that he had translated.

THE PATRISTIC TRANSLATIONS DEDICATED TO NICHOLAS V

The patristic texts that were translated for Nicholas V are the following:

1. Chrysostom's *Homiliae XC in Matthaeum*, translated by George of Trebizond (1396–1472/1473) in 1448¹⁴
2. Eusebius's *De praeparatione evangelica*, translated by George of Trebizond in 1448¹⁵

¹² Da Bisticci, *Le vite*, 1:66–67.

¹³ "Intentione di papa Nicola era di fare una libreria in Sancto Piero, per comune uso di tutta la corte di Roma, che sarebe suto cosa mirabile, se si poteva conducere, ma preventivo dalla morte non si potè finire. Aluminò la Scrittura Sancta d'infiniti libri, e' quali fece tradurre, et simili de' gentili, et alcuni in gramatica, necessarii alla lingua latina." Da Bisticci, *Le vite*, 1:65; the English translation is from Vespasiano da Bisticci, *The Vespasiano Memoirs: Lives of Illustrious Men of the XVth Century*, trans. William George and Emily Waters (Toronto: University of Toronto Press, 1997 [1926]), 50.

¹⁴ For this translation, see John Monfasani, *Collectanea Trapezuntiana: Texts, Documents, and Bibliographies of George of Trebizond* (Binghamton: Center for Medieval and Early Renaissance Studies, State University of New York at Binghamton, 1984), 729–44 (Text CLXXXII). For the preface, see Monfasani, *Collectanea Trapezuntiana*, 289–91 (Text XC). For George of Trebizond's life and works, including his translations, see John Monfasani, *George of Trebizond: A Biography and a Study of His Rhetoric and Logic* (Leiden: Brill, 1976); Monfasani, *Collectanea Trapezuntiana*.

¹⁵ For this translation, see Monfasani, *Collectanea Trapezuntiana*, 721–26 (Text CLXXVIII); for the preface to Nicholas V, see Monfasani, *Collectanea Trapezuntiana*, 291–93 (Text XCI). See also Monfasani, *George of Trebizond*, 72–73.

3. Cyril of Alexandria's *Super evangelium Iohannis*, translated by George of Trebizond in 1448 or 1449¹⁶
4. Pseudo-Chrysostom's *Sermones de patientia Job et de poenitentia*, translated by Lelio Tifernate (1417–86) in 1449¹⁷
5. Gregory of Nazianzus's orations nos. 43, *In Basilium Magnum*, and 21, *In Athanasium*, translated by George of Trebizond in 1451 or 1452¹⁸
6. Basil's *De invidia et odio*, translated by Niccolò Perotti (1429–80), probably in the late 1440s¹⁹

Other patristic translations can be associated with Nicholas, although less directly. Francesco Griffolini (1420–91) presented a Greek manuscript of Chrysostom to the pope in late 1453 or early 1454. He had probably meant to translate Chrysostom for Nicholas, but the pope's death in the spring of 1455 forced him to look for patronage elsewhere.²⁰ Furthermore, Nicholas acquired a manuscript of Origen's *Contra Celsum* and wanted Theodore Gaza (1398–1478) to make a translation of it, but this never materialized.²¹

¹⁶ For this translation, see Monfasani, *Collectanea Trapezuntiana*, 715–17 (Text CLXXV). For George's preface, see Monfasani, *Collectanea Trapezuntiana*, 293–98 (Text XCII). See also Monfasani, *George of Trebizond*, 72–73.

¹⁷ For this translation, see Ursula Jaitner-Hahner, *Humanismus in Umbrien und Rom: Lilius Tifernas, Kanzler und Gelehrter des Quattrocento* (Baden-Baden: Koerner, 1993), 314–31; Laura Saccardi, "Appunti sulla traduzione crisostomica di Lilio Libelli: L'omelia VI *De poenitentia* (Περὶ νηστείας)," in *Gregorio e Lilio: Due Tifernati protagonisti dell'umanesimo italiano*, ed. John Butcher, Andrea Czortek, and Matteo Martelli (Umbertide: University Book, 2018), 235–48; Laura Saccardi, "Ancora sulla traduzione crisostomica di Lilio Libelli: L'omelia I in *Genesim*," in *La traduzione latina dei classici greci nel quattrocento in Toscana e in Umbria: Nel 575º anniversario della scomparsa di Leonardo Bruni (9 marzo 1444)*, ed. John Butcher and Giulio Firpo (Umbertide: University Book, 2020), 285–90. On the dating, see Jaitner-Hahner, *Humanismus in Umbrien und Rom*, 314–15.

¹⁸ For this translation, see Sister Agnes Clare Way (C.D.P.), "Gregorius Nazianzenus," in *Catalogus Translationum et Commentariorum*, ed. Paul Oskar Kristeller and F. Edward Cranz (Washington, DC: Catholic University of America Press, 1971), 2:136–38. See also Monfasani, *Collectanea Trapezuntiana*, 726–27 (Texts CLXXIX–CLXXX). For the preface, see Monfasani, *Collectanea Trapezuntiana*, 300–301 (Text XCV).

¹⁹ Perotti's translation of Basil has not received much scholarly attention. It is touched upon in Giancarlo Abbamonte and Fabio Stok, "Perotti traduttore degli opuscoli plutarchei *De Alexandri Magni fortuna aut virtute* e *De fortuna romanorum*," *Renaissanceforum: Tidsskrift for Renaissanceforskning* 7 (2011): 217–60. On the dating of Perotti's translations, see Abbamonte and Stok, "Perotti traduttore," 218–22.

²⁰ Teodoro Lorini, "Committenze crisostomiche di Niccolò V," in *Niccolò V nel sesto centenario della nascita*, 295–327, esp. 323–27.

²¹ See below, p. 332–33.

Out of the six patristic translations listed above, four were made at the pope's explicit request. For the first one, that of Chrysostom's *Homiliae XC in Matthaeum*, he employed the Byzantine scholar George of Trebizond.²² At the time, George had already translated Basil's *Contra Eunomium* and *De Spiritu Sancto*, which he had dedicated to Pope Eugenius IV in 1442.²³ Nicholas possibly commissioned the translation of Chrysostom because Traversari had planned to make one for Eugenius IV.²⁴ The *Homiliae* had already been translated partly by Anianus Celedensis in the fifth century, and Nicholas asked George to translate the remaining part.

Soon afterward, George made a translation of Eusebius's *De praeparatione evangelica*. This time, Nicholas not only commissioned the translation but also gave explicit instructions to remove some heterodox passages. George explained in the preface to the translation that he had followed the pope's orders, lest someone should criticize him for taking liberties with the text.²⁵ George's translations of Cyril of Alexandria and of Gregory of Nazianzus were also made at Nicholas's request, as we learn from his prefaces to the pope.²⁶

Nicholas's close involvement with George's patristic translations was not exceptional. Many prefaces to Greek-Latin translations that are addressed to Nicholas V refer to a commission or request. Of the twenty-two prefaces that I have seen, sixteen mention such a request explicitly. The pope's involvement also appears in other ways. Nicholas provided the source texts for several translations, often from his own Greek library, or through his connection with Cardinal Bessarion, who held the most complete Greek library in Italy at the time.²⁷ It is likely that for George's translation of

²² For George's life and works, see above, n. 14.

²³ For these translations, see Christina Abenstein, *Die Basilien-Übersetzung des Georg von Trapezunt in ihrem historischen Kontext* (Berlin: De Gruyter, 2014); *Die Basilien-Übersetzung des Georg von Trapezunt: Edition* (Berlin: De Gruyter, 2015).

²⁴ Monfasani, *Collectanea Trapezuntiana*, 735.

²⁵ Monfasani, *Collectanea Trapezuntiana*, 292.

²⁶ For George's preface to Cyril, see Monfasani, *Collectanea Trapezuntiana*, 293–98 (Text XCII); for the preface to Gregory of Nazianzus, 300–301 (Text XCV).

²⁷ E.g., Nicholas provided the Greek text in the case of Niccolò Perotti's translation of Polybius, and Lelio Tifernate's translation of Philo of Alexandria. For Nicholas's Greek library, see n. 9 above. Perotti's translation of Epictetus was based on a manuscript from Bessarion's library. On Bessarion's library, see Lotte Labowsky, *Bessarion's Library and the Biblioteca Marciana: Six Early Inventories* (Rome: Storia e letteratura, 1979); Brigitte Mondrain, "Le Cardinal Bessarion et la constitution de sa collection de manuscrits grecs," in *"Inter graecos latinissimus, inter latinos graecissimus": Bessarion zwischen den Kulturen*, ed. Claudia Märkl, Christian Kaiser, and Thomas Ricklin (Berlin: De Gruyter, 2013), 187–202.

Cyril, Nicholas arranged for a Greek source that belonged to Bessarion's collection.²⁸

In some cases, however, translators did not wait for a commission but dedicated a work to the pope on their own initiative. This happened in the case of two patristic translations. Lelio Tifernate translated sixteen sermons ascribed to Chrysostom, picking them thematically. Lelio had begun his career as a translator in the late 1430s and had previously dedicated a translation of Philo of Alexandria to Nicholas.²⁹ In the preface to his translation of Chrysostom, he did not mention a commission. Rather, he presented his work as a spontaneous homage to the pope, on the occasion of the Jubilee in 1450.³⁰

Niccolò Perotti dedicated many translations to Nicholas, which included one patristic work: Basil's *De invidia et odio*.³¹ The preface suggests that Perotti made this translation on his own initiative.³² For this reason, scholars have suggested that it was among the first works that Perotti dedicated to Nicholas, possibly the first of all.³³ If this is true, Perotti used his translation of Basil as a way to curry favor with the pope, paving the way for the later translations he would make at Nicholas's request.³⁴

NICHOLAS'S INTEREST IN PATRISTIC TRANSLATIONS

There are some indications that Nicholas was particularly interested in translations of patristic texts. We have already seen Vespasiano's comment quoted above, which suggests that the pope invested in translations that

²⁸ Monfasani, *Collectanea Trapezuntiana*, 716–17.

²⁹ Jaitner-Hahner, *Humanismus in Umbrien und Rom*, 335–44.

³⁰ Jaitner-Hahner, *Humanismus in Umbrien und Rom*, 473.

³¹ Stinger, "Italian Renaissance Learning," 494. For an overview of scholarship on Perotti, see Jean-Louis Charlet, "Niccolò Perotti, humaniste du Quattrocento: Bibliographie critique," *Renaissanceforum: Tidsskrift for Renaessanceforskning* 7, no. 1 (2011): 1–72. For the manuscripts of Perotti's translation of Basil, see Abbamonte and Stok, "Perotti traduttore," 217–60, at 254–56, as well as Charlet, "Niccolò Perotti," 20n127.

³² MS Biblioteca Apostolica Vaticana, Urb. lat. 297, 144v–145v.

³³ On the dating of Perotti's translations, see Abbamonte and Stok, "Perotti traduttore," 218–22.

³⁴ For Perotti as a translator, see Marianne Pade, "Niccolò Perotti and the Ars Traducendi," in *Sol et Homo: Mensch und Natur in der Renaissance. Festschrift zum 70. Geburtstag für Eckhard Keßler*, ed. Thomas Ricklin, Helga Pirner-Pareschi, and Sabrina Ebbersmeyer (Paderborn: Wilhelm Fink, 2008), 79–100; Marianne Pade, "Intertextuality as a Stylistic Device in Niccolò Perotti's Dedicatory Letters," *Renaissanceforum: Tidsskrift for Renaessanceforskning* 7 (2011): 121–46.

would help elucidate the Bible.³⁵ Note also that the first translation that Nicholas commissioned was a patristic text: Chrysostom's *Homiliae in Matthaeum*. Furthermore, Nicholas apparently found the translation of Eusebius important enough to give George instructions about it.

In addition, a clue to Nicholas's interest in patristics is found in George's preface to his translation of Cyril. After summing up the translations he had already made for the pope, he added: "All these works I have already elucidated for the common good, as you ordered. And you take pains that no fewer jewels of the Latin language and spiritual works of the Catholic church are prepared, extended, and supported by others . . . You try to restore the sanctity of the pristine church, the religion of the Fathers, and the sincerity of the faith; indeed, you have already done all that was in your power to restore these."³⁶ It is unclear, however, if this preface is representative: although expressions about the "common good" also appear elsewhere,³⁷ the particular theme of restoring the pristine church is not echoed in other dedications.

Another source that sheds more light on Nicholas's vision for patristic translations is a letter written by one of the translators employed at his court: Theodore Gaza. Years after Nicholas's death, in the early 1470s, Gaza wrote to Cristoforo Persona (1416–86), encouraging him to make a translation of Origen's *Contra Celsum*. He wrote that he had considered translating this text himself, because it would have been suitable for Nicholas's translation program:

Shortly afterward I saw your Athanasius with you, whose translation delighted me so much that from that time, I became hopeful that you would be able to translate Origen's *Contra Celsum* as well. Since this book is very elegant and written in defense of the Christian faith, Pope Nicholas, although he was most desirous of his own account for new works, and especially Greek ones, on my encouragement sent someone to Constantinople to buy it for him and bring it back, and upon its arrival soon afterwards he showed it to

³⁵ See above, p. 328.

³⁶ "Hec omnia per me iam communi utilitati, ut iussisti, exposita sunt. Nec pauciora per alios Latine lingue ac ecclesie Catholice ornamenta opesque spirituales parare, amplificare, stabilireque studeo . . . et . . . priscam ecclesie sanctimoniam, religionem patrum, fideique sinceritatem reducere conaris, imo vero quantum in te est iam reduxisti." Monfasani, *Collectanea Trapezuntiana*, 294. The translation is mine.

³⁷ E.g., in George's preface to his translation of Chrysostom. Monfasani, *Collectanea Trapezuntiana*, 290.

me, and said and that he wanted to promise any price to him who would translate it into Latin. And naturally I would have taken up this work myself, and willingly, had not another serious translation occupied me at the time. Therefore, that book remains still in the papal library, untouched and, in my opinion, preserved for you.³⁸

This passage suggests that the manuscript of *Contra Celsum* entered the papal library to be translated, and also that it was kept there for the same purpose, even after Nicholas's death. Gaza also writes that Nicholas, who was already eager to add more Greek classics to his collection, was easily persuaded to take an interest in a work "written in defense of the Christian faith." Later on in the same letter, Gaza remarks that after Nicholas's death, translating such texts had become less lucrative, but that it could still work in Persona's favor.³⁹ All this indicates that Nicholas actively promoted the making of this translation. On the other hand, Nicholas's motivation does not appear to have been very specific: Gaza writes that he was "desirous for new works, especially Greek ones," without specifying patristic works. The appreciation of *Contra Celsum* for its defense of the Christian faith may well be due to Gaza rather than Nicholas.

PATRISTIC TRANSLATIONS IN THE CONTEXT OF NICHOLAS'S LITERARY PATRONAGE

In practice, the patristic output of Nicholas's translation program was modest. Among the works that he commissioned, patristic texts are not better represented than other genres; alongside four translations of patristic texts, all entrusted to George of Trebizond, Nicholas also commissioned translations of historical works by Plutarch, Dionysius of Halicarnassus, Diodorus

³⁸ "Vidi paulopost apud te Athanasium tuum, cuius traductio ita me oblectavit, ut in spem bonam eo ex tempore venerim posse te et Origenem adversum Celsum traducere; quem librum, quia elegantissimus est et in fidei Christianae defensionem conscriptus, Nicolaus pontifex, etsi de se erat novorum operum et Graecorum praecipue cupientissimus, meo hortatu Constantinopolim misit qui ad se coemptum deferret, delatumque mox mihi ostendit dixitque velle se ei quidvis praemii polliceri, qui Latinum hunc faceret. Et sane ipse id opus aggressus essem ac lubens, nisi me tunc alia gravis traductio praeoccupasset. Restat igitur adhuc liber iste in pontificis bibliotheca intactus et, ut arbitror, tibi servatus." Theodorus Gaza, *Epistolae*, ed. Pietro Luigi Leone (Naples: M. D'Auria, 1990), 79–80. The translation is mine.

³⁹ Gaza, *Epistolae*, 80.

Siculus, Polybius, Thucydides, and Herodotus, and of works in philosophy and natural history by Alexander of Aphrodisias, Theophrastus, Aristotle, and Plato. The patristic translations form only a small portion of the overall output of the pope's translation program.

Furthermore, Nicholas was apparently not so eager to make George's translations available to a wide circle of readers. In February 1450, when George had already translated Chrysostom, Eusebius, and Cyril for Nicholas, he complained in a letter that the pope did not want to disseminate his translation of Chrysostom, nor any other of his translations: "Our Lord [the pope] has never wished to hand over to anyone for transcription either Chrysostomus or any other work dedicated by me to His Holiness. Why he does this, I do not know."⁴⁰ Nicholas's reluctance to let George's translation of Chrysostom go out of his hands did not prevent its further dissemination.⁴¹ However, it indicates that the pope did little to promote the circulation of the translations dedicated to him. Apparently, he did not lend his own manuscripts out for copying, not only in the case of George's translations but also, for example, in the case of Valla's translation of Thucydides.⁴² We can only speculate as to the reason—perhaps he was anxious to keep the collection complete at all times.

DISSEMINATION

Inside the papal library, patristic translations did not hold a prominent place either. The Greek section of the Vatican library held many patristic texts in Nicholas's day. The works of Gregory of Nazianzus, Basil, and Chrysostom are all well represented.⁴³ Some of the patristic translations made for Nicholas also found their way to the library. Of Chrysostom's *Homiliae in*

⁴⁰ "Dominus autem noster meminisse unquam nec Chrysostomum, nec aliud a me sanctitatis suae opus dedicatum tradere transcribendum voluit, quod cur faciat ignoro." Latin original and English translation are quoted (slightly modified) from Monfasani, *George of Trebizond*, 76.

⁴¹ See below, p. 335–36.

⁴² George of Trebizond, *Vindicatio Aristotelis: Two Works of George of Trebizond in the Plato-Aristotle Controversy of the Fifteenth Century*, ed. John Monfasani (Tempe: Arizona Center for Medieval Studies, 2021), 24–25n112.

⁴³ Chrysostom in forty manuscripts (Devreesse, *Le fonds grec*, 11–14 [nos. 1–40]); Basil in eighteen manuscripts (14–15 [nos. 41–59]); Gregory of Nazianzus in sixteen manuscripts (15–17 [nos. 60–75]). In addition, works of Chrysostom and Gregory of Nazianzus appear on the lists of manuscripts borrowed by Cardinal Isidore of Kiev and Cardinal Bessarion (Devreesse, *Le fonds grec* [nos. 37–41]). Of Cyril, however, there is only one manuscript: MS Biblioteca Apostolica Vaticana, Vat. gr. 596 (19 [no. 100]).

Matthaeum there was a copy of Anianus's translation, with annotations both by George and by Tommaso Parentucelli,⁴⁴ as well as a copy of Anianus's translation in combination with that of George of Trebizond.⁴⁵ There were also two copies of George's translation of Eusebius,⁴⁶ as well as two copies of George's translation of Cyril.⁴⁷ However, there was no copy of George's translation of Gregory of Nazianzus,⁴⁸ nor of Lelio's translation of Pseudo-Chrysostom⁴⁹ or Perotti's translation of Basil.⁵⁰ Nicholas also kept some Latin manuscripts in a smaller library in his private quarters.⁵¹ Out of the fifty-one books Nicholas is known to have kept there, only two are patristic translations: George's translation of Eusebius and Bruni's translations of Dionysius the Areopagite.⁵²

Although Nicholas apparently did little to promote the further dissemination of the patristic translations made for him, most of them circulated widely, both in manuscript and print. George's translation of Chrysostom's *Homiliae* enjoyed a considerable circulation, with eighteen manuscripts and

⁴⁴ Vat. lat. 387; Manfredi, *I codici latini*, 43 [no. 70].

⁴⁵ Vat. lat. 385; Manfredi, *I codici latini*, 42 [no. 68]. There were also a copy of Chrysostom's commentary *In Matthaeum* in the translation of Burgundio of Pisa, Vat. lat. 383 (Manfredi, *I codici latini*, 47–48 [no. 76]), and four manuscripts of other works by Chrysostom: Vat. lat. 477 + 502 (84–85 [no. 133]); Vat. lat. 555 (100–101 [no. 156]); Vat. lat. 306 (118 [no. 185]); Vat. lat. 413 (350 [no. 560]).

⁴⁶ Vat. lat. 228 and 234; Manfredi, *I codici latini*, 245–46; 250 [nos. 387 and 395]. Other manuscripts of works by Eusebius in the Vatican library: Vat. lat. 629 (217–18 [no. 348]); Vat. lat. 239 (235–36 [no. 375]); Vat. lat. 245 (248–49 [no. 392]); Vat. lat. 238 (343 [no. 550]); and an unidentified manuscript (292–93 [no. 465]).

⁴⁷ Vat. lat. 528 (Manfredi, *I codici latini*, 46–47 [no. 75]); Vat. lat. 526 (281–82 [no. 447]). There was also a copy of Cyril's *Epistulae* in Latin, Vat. lat. 1344 (237–38 [no. 378]).

⁴⁸ There were copies of other works by Gregory of Nazianzus, however: of Antonio da Todi's Latin translation of Gregory's *De virtute* (Vat. lat. 3082; Manfredi, *I codici latini*, 382–83 [no. 610]) and of several of Gregory's *Orationes* in the translation of Rufinus of Aquileia (Vat. lat. 208; Manfredi, *I codici latini*, 44 [no. 71], and Vat. lat. 306; 118 [no. 185]). There were also copies of Traversari's translation of Gregory's *Orationes* IV and III *De pace* in Vat. lat. 555 (Manfredi, *I codici latini*, 100–101 [no. 156]).

⁴⁹ There was, however, a copy of Lelio's translation of Philo: Manfredi, *I codici latini*, 307–8 [no. 492].

⁵⁰ There were copies of other translations of Basil's works, however: one of *Contra Eunomium* in the translation of George of Trebizond: Vat. lat. 299 (Manfredi, *I codici latini*, 474 [no. 760]); a few others of Basil's *De legendis antiquorum libris*, in the translation of Leonardo Bruni (Vat. lat. 1877; Manfredi, *I codici latini*, 236–37 [no. 377] and Vat. lat. 1807; 267–68 [no. 424]).

⁵¹ On Nicholas's *cubiculum*, see Manfredi, *I codici latini*, XC–XCII. The manuscripts that were in Nicholas's *cubiculum* are listed on 507–11.

⁵² Vat. lat. 228 or 234 for Eusebius (Manfredi, *I codici latini*, 507 [no. 4]) and Vat. lat. 2066 for Dionysius (510 [no. 27]).

thirty-six printed editions between ca. 1466 and 1723.⁵³ Of George's translation of Eusebius, twenty-seven manuscripts are known, together with sixteen editions issued between 1470 and 1581.⁵⁴ George's translation of Cyril is extant in nine manuscripts, and eleven printed editions between 1508/9 and 1604.⁵⁵ In all likelihood, George's translation of Gregory of Nazianzus was never presented to the pope, and it was not printed. It is extant in seven manuscripts.⁵⁶ As for Lelio's translation of Chrysostom's *Sermones*, there are thirty manuscript copies of this translation, next to the dedication copy.⁵⁷ Lelio's translation was printed twenty-one times between ca. 1467 and 1588.⁵⁸ A recent study on Perotti's translations lists sixteen manuscripts for the translation of Basil's *De invidia*: twelve of them also include Perotti's translations of Plutarch's work on the same topic.⁵⁹ Perotti's translation of Basil was printed seven times between 1496 and 1508.⁶⁰ In short, the patristic translations made for Nicholas would eventually have an impact far beyond the papal court.

CONCLUSIONS

In the introduction to this article, I raised the question of whether patristic translations held a special place within Nicholas's translation program. When we consider these translations in the broader context of his literary patronage and collecting habits, we find that their status is ambiguous. On the one hand, Nicholas was closely involved with the patristic translations of George of Trebizond, and Perotti chose a patristic text to recommend himself to the pope as a translator. Some comments by translators suggest that Nicholas was particularly interested in patristic translations. On the other hand, Nicholas did not invest more in patristic translations than in

⁵³ Monfasani, *Collectanea Trapezuntiana*, 729–33.

⁵⁴ Monfasani, *Collectanea Trapezuntiana*; Mariarosa Cortesi and Silvia Fiaschi, *Repertorio delle traduzioni umanistiche a stampa: Secoli XV–XVI* (Florence: SISMEL, Edizioni del Galluzzo, 2008), 1:476–79.

⁵⁵ Monfasani, *Collectanea Trapezuntiana*, 715–16. See also Cortesi and Fiaschi, *Repertorio*, 1:391–93.

⁵⁶ Monfasani, *Collectanea Trapezuntiana*, 726–27; Way, "Gregorius Nazianzenus," 136.

⁵⁷ The dedication copy of Chrysostom's *Sermones* was probably Vat.lat.406. Jaitner-Hahner, *Humanismus in Umbrien und Rom*, 314.

⁵⁸ Cortesi and Fiaschi, *Repertorio*, 1:772–76. On the dissemination of this translation, see also Jaitner-Hahner, *Humanismus in Umbrien und Rom*, 326–31.

⁵⁹ Abbamonte and Stok, "Perotti traduttore," 254–55, and 256n123.

⁶⁰ Cortesi and Fiaschi, *Repertorio*, 1:334–36.

other works; he did not keep many patristic texts in his personal library; and he had little interest in disseminating the patristic translations that were dedicated to him.

The above analysis has shown that it is in fact difficult to treat these translations as one group: the patristic translations do not form a clearly defined corpus within Nicholas's translation program, and they did not have a special status. While a more systematic translation program for patristics would have fit well in Nicholas's patronage, in practice, it appears that his support for patristic translations was mostly incidental.

Radboud University.